PARTICIPANT HANDBOOK · 2026

Hackathon Guide

November 13–14, 2026 | All times are Cairo local time

> **IMPORTANT UPDATE** Every team member must join the Discord server once access details are shared. The server information, user guide, and mentorship instructions will be sent separately by Thursday, November 12.

01 | Before the hackathon

Prepare in advance by watching the sessions on the Space Apps Cairo YouTube channel. They cover understanding the challenges, developing solutions, and preparing for the hackathon.

Follow the official event announcements for any confirmed schedule changes, submission instructions, and final deadlines.

02 | Event schedule

Stage	Date and time
Onsite registration and opening	Friday, Nov 13 · from 9:00 AM
Hackathon begins	Friday, Nov 13 · 1:00 PM
Mentorship begins	Friday, Nov 13 · 2:00 PM (Saturday end time to be confirmed)
Project submission	Saturday, Nov 14 · 1:00 PM (confirm the final deadline)
Closing ceremony and winners	Saturday, Nov 14 · approximately 5:00 PM

03 | How to participate

Virtual participants

Join remotely from **10:00 AM on Friday, November 13**. Remain available for announcements, opening talks, mentorship, and hackathon activities through the event communication channels.

You are welcome to attend the closing ceremony onsite at approximately **5:00 PM on Saturday, November 14**. Attendance is optional; the final timing will be announced by the organizing team.

Onsite participants

All onsite team members must arrive at **Elsewedy University of Technology by 9:00 AM on Friday, November 13** for registration and team allocation.

You may stay overnight or leave and return early on Saturday. If you leave, notify the registration desk and check in again when you return.

> **ONSITE CAPACITY RULE** A team with six members may have only five members attend onsite. The sixth member must participate virtually.

04 | Mentorship process

Mentors will help your team plan its work, overcome challenges, and strengthen its solution through technical or conceptual feedback.

- **They can:** guide your approach, answer questions, and suggest improvements.
- **They cannot:** write code or complete the solution on your behalf.

How to request support

All teams, onsite and virtual, will be able to request mentorship through Discord. The server access and step-by-step instructions will be provided separately by Thursday, November 12. Some onsite mentoring will also be available during peak hours.

Mentor availability

Mentorship starts on Friday at 2:00 PM. The precise end time on Saturday will be confirmed in the event announcements. Availability varies by mentor, and overnight support may be limited.

Available mentorship tracks

Technical & creative tracks	More tracks
• AI & Machine Learning	• Data Science & Analytics
• Augmented & Virtual Reality (AR/VR)	• Storytelling
• Game Development	• Storytelling & Video Editing
• 3D Modeling & Animation	• Web Development
• Art & Visualization	• Software Engineering
• Mobile App Development	• GIS & Remote Sensing
• UI/UX Design	

05 | Project submission checklist

Prepare each of the following before submitting your project:

- **Project demo:** A seven-slide presentation or a 30-second video uploaded to a publicly accessible platform. Your demo must not include the images, names, or voices of anyone under 18, in accordance with NASA Space Apps policies.
- **Project links:** The final project link, GitHub repository, and any relevant development or code links.
- **Project summary:** A concise description of the problem, your solution, its impact, and how it meets the selected challenge.
- **Project resources:** The datasets, sources, references, and tools used to develop your solution.

For NASA Space Apps participation and content policies, review the official policies.

06 | Judging and awards

Projects are evaluated against five core NASA Space Apps judging criteria:

Criterion	What your project should demonstrate
Impact	The problem addressed, who benefits, and the difference the solution could make.
Creativity	An original approach or a meaningful improvement on existing ideas.
Validity	Sound science, reliable data, and a feasible approach that supports your claims.
Relevance	A clear response to your chosen challenge and its specific requirements.
Presentation	A clear explanation of the problem, solution, supporting evidence, and value.

Submission rules

- Only the **team leader** should submit the project.
- All submitted links must open **without passwords, account registration, or access requests**.
- Submit before the confirmed deadline. **Late submissions will not be accepted.**

Recognition and awards

Cairo will select **10 Global Nominees**, in addition to Sponsor Awards. For details, see the Participant Handbook – Award Categories.

Teams shortlisted for the **People's Choice Award** will be announced during the closing ceremony and asked to present their projects. Shortlisted teams should be ready to present.

07 | Venue guidelines

- **Smoke-free venue:** Smoking is not permitted.
- **Bring your equipment:** Laptop, charger, and required hardware. Inform the organizers in advance about any additional equipment.
- **Internet:** Free Wi-Fi is shared and may be congested. Bring a backup connection if your project relies on internet access.
- **Overnight rest:** Separate rooms are available for rest only; sleeping facilities are not provided. Bring a sleeping bag and personal essentials.
- **Event support:** Ask volunteers for directions, registration help, Wi-Fi, or electrical assistance.
- **Health and safety:** Notify a volunteer immediately if you feel unwell or need medical attention.

08 | Code of ethics and onsite entry

- **Respect others:** Harassment, discrimination, bullying, and abusive behavior are not permitted.
- **Work honestly:** Credit your sources, respect copyright, and disclose AI use.
- **Follow event guidance:** Respect instructions from organizers and mentors.
- **Own your submission:** Your team is responsible for its final submission. Changes are not allowed after submission.
- **Care for the venue:** Respect shared spaces and report concerns to event organizers or volunteers.
- **Entry and movement:** Arrive during registration hours and remain within designated event areas.
- **Identification:** Bring your national ID. If you are under 16, bring your birth certificate and contact the organizing team in advance.